

Help Validate Timed Acupressure for Jet Lag

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Introduction

Jet lag affects many international travelers. Common strategies such as sunrise timing, melatonin, sleep shifts, and meal timing help some people but not all.¹ Acupuncturists have long proposed another approach.

Nearly 50 years ago, Khoe² and Amaro in 2001³ suggested that stimulating horary points based on destination time during travel might help the body adjust before arrival. This targets jet lag's circadian misalignment. Case reports and theory support the idea but no formal study has tested it in real travelers. We build an app that gives a 24-hour schedule of timed acupressure points to use during travel.

If you plan international travel, we invite you to try the app and, if you choose, join the research.

Circadian Biology: How Internal Clocks Work

Research shows that circadian rhythms align body processes to a roughly 24-hour cycle. The suprachiasmatic nucleus (SCN) in the brain acts as the master clock with light is its main signal.^{4,5} The SCN helps coordinate “peripheral clocks” in organs such as the liver and heart, including effects on blood vessels and blood pressure.^{6,7} Clock genes run a feedback loop that creates daily rhythms in gene activity.⁸ Zeitgebers, which are external cues such as light, temperature, activity, and meals help keep these rhythms on track.⁹

Jet lag happens when fast travel across time zones throws these clocks out of sync.

A 2024 review reports that acupuncture can affect circadian biology, including clock genes, neurotransmitters, and sleep–wake cycles.¹⁰ Those studies used sleep-related points, but they support a broader idea: acupuncture may act as a non-photic zeitgeber providing a cue that can shift rhythms without bright light.

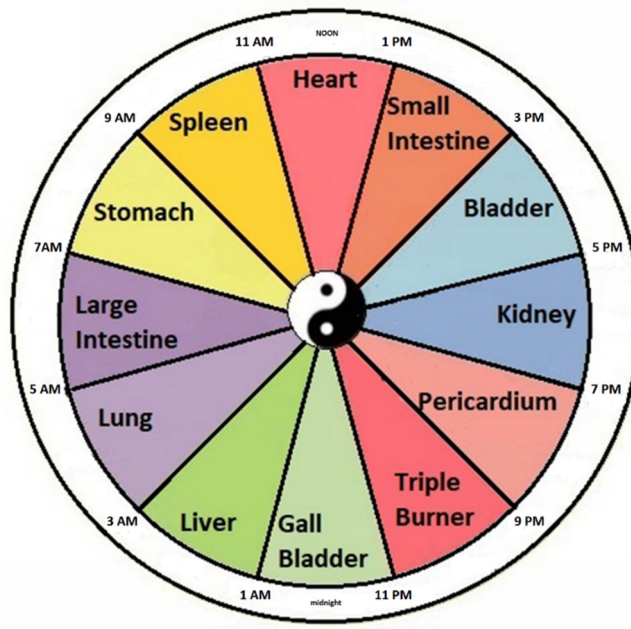


Figure 1: 24-hour Organ Clock

Table 1: 24-hour Schedule

Time Range	Meridian / Organ System	Horary -> Suggested Point
3:00 AM – 5:00 AM	Lung	LU-8
5:00 AM – 7:00 AM	Large Intestine	LI-1
7:00 AM – 9:00 AM	Stomach	ST-36
9:00 AM – 11:00 AM	Spleen	SP-3 -> SP-10*
11:00 AM – 1:00 PM	Heart	HT-8
1:00 PM – 3:00 PM	Small Intestine	SI-5
3:00 PM – 5:00 PM	Bladder	BL-66 -> BL-2*
5:00 PM – 7:00 PM	Kidney	KI-10 -> KI-27*
7:00 PM – 9:00 PM	Pericardium	PC-8
9:00 PM – 11:00 PM	San Jiao (Triple Warmer)	SJ-6
11:00 PM – 1:00 AM	Gallbladder	GB-41 -> GB-20*
1:00 AM – 3:00 AM	Liver	LIV-1 -> LIV-8*

Table 1

*The * suggested points are modifications implemented for practical accessibility.*

Point Changes for Practical Accessibility

Amaro recommended the actual horary points on each meridian. But early testers flying economy class often did not want to remove their shoes to reach the ankle and foot points. We substituted easier to reach points on the same meridian thinking that it would be better than skipping that time window altogether.

For easier location, we chose to use SP-10 for SP-3, BL-2 for BL-66, GB-20 for GB-41, LIV-8 for LIV-1, and KI-27 for KI-10 (see Table 1). In TCM, stimulating any point on a meridian can

influence the whole channel so these swaps keep the same meridian timing while improving access.

How to participate



On your iPhone, get the app at <https://jetlagpro.com/#download>. The website has step-by-step instructions. The app is free with no add-ons, upgrades or ads. After install, follow the in-app directions for timing and instructions. If you have questions, email us info@jetlagpro.com.

Research in plain terms: After a qualifying trip, you may be asked to share anonymous trip data for research. If you elect to share, you may later get an optional symptom survey. We do not collect your name or email.

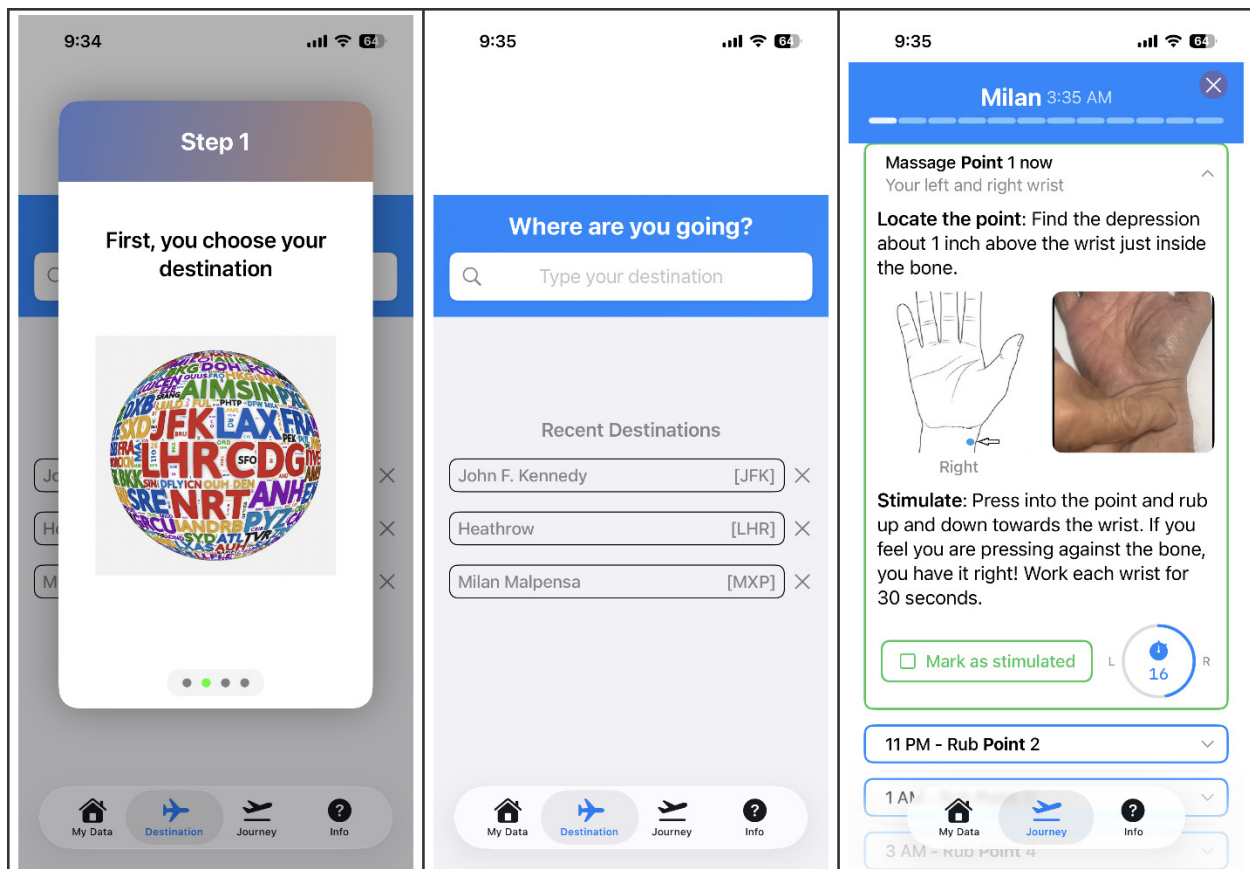


Figure 2 – The Three Steps

Scheduled reminders pop up over the next 24 hours to prompt the traveler to do the next point. The reminders are persistent and remain on the user's phone (or Apple Watch) until tapped.

When tapped, the traveler is shown the correct point image beside a looping video showing how to stimulate the point.

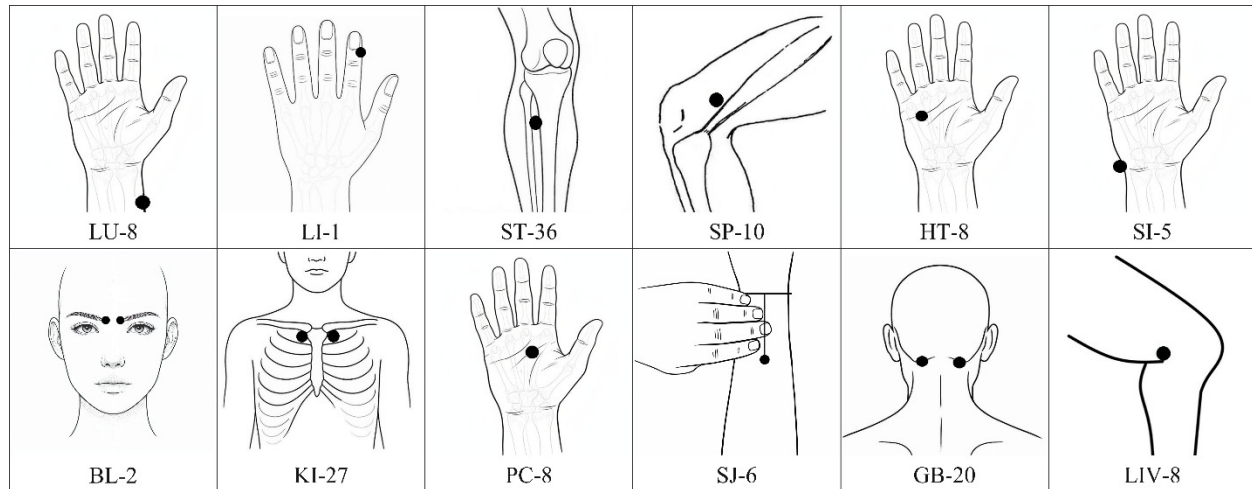


Figure 3 – Point Images

When the trip ends, the app may save anonymous data on which points you marked and your origin and arrival time zones. About two days later, you may get a short optional survey based on core symptom areas from the Liverpool Jet Lag Questionnaire (LJLQ). Research sharing is your choice (Share / Not now in the app)

Data Analysis

Our main question: Is greater use of the scheduled acupressure points associated with lower reported jet lag symptoms in real travelers? We will compare survey answers to expected severity by time zones crossed, using Waterhouse et al. (2007) as a reference.¹ We will group trips by how many points were stimulated and how many time zones were crossed. This is an observational study and is pre-registered at Open Science Framework: osf.io/jm4w7.

Discussion

Controlled jet lag trials are hard because every trip differs in terms of sleep, light, caffeine, health, and environment. This observational study works with that reality. We ask whether more point use is associated with symptom reports in real travel. We are not asking if the app proves a treatment effect. We aim for roughly 500 qualifying trips so we can describe patterns with reasonable precision.

References

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